

can also use a video game console connected to your television, such as the Sony PlayStation 3 or the Microsoft Xbox 360, to stream the media from a NAS to your TV.

In order to complete the circuit, you'll need a router; preferably one equipped with wireless and wired gigabit ethernet. In most cases, gigabit ethernet provides a smoother playback experience with high-definition content.

NAS boxes with UPnP media servers also offer other media-centric features such as an iTunes server. What this translates into is you can simply store your songs on the drive, and the iTunes server will create a shared iTunes library that shows up automatically under the "Shared" heading of the iTunes navigation panel on your PC, or via your DMA. This little trick saves you the hassle of adding songs to every iteration of iTunes on your network.

► **Backing up data to your NAS**

Since a NAS can hold many large drives, it's a popular option for backing up data. FreeNAS recommends a software called Rsync for backup, but there are better alternatives. Microsoft SyncToy, is a case in point. In case you're a Mac user, you can use Time Machine with your NAS.

Backing up with SyncToy

So if you have to back up a folder or even a group of folders on Windows, you first need to download and install SyncToy. SyncToy is extremely simple to use: all you need to do is create a new folder pair, using the "left" folder as the folder from your computer that you want to back up, and the "right" folder as the folder on your NAS to which you're backing up those files. You have three different types of sync: Synchronize, Echo and Contribute.

- Synchronize will keep the two folders in sync at all times, so if you change or delete something on one side, it will sync those changes to the other side.
- Echo will only sync changes you make from the left side (your computer)– if you change or delete anything on the NAS, those changes won't be synced back.
- Contribute does the same thing as Echo, but won't sync over deletions. This means if you accidentally delete a file from your hard drive, it will still be on the NAS, and you can go grab it and replace it. When you're done, you can run your first sync and make sure all the files copied over correctly.